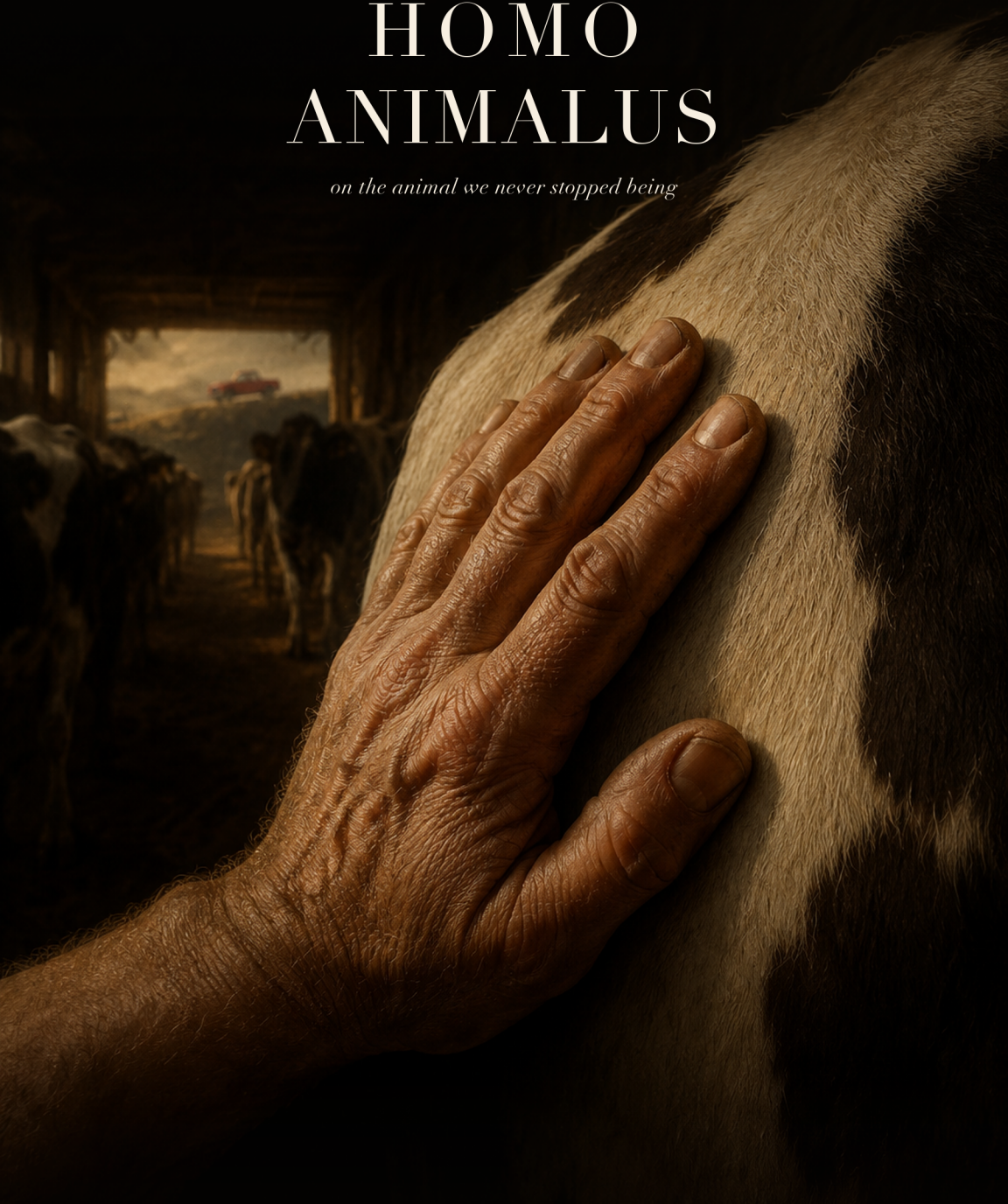


NARRATIVE NONFICTION

HOMO ANIMALUS

on the animal we never stopped being



ANDRIES J. GREYLING

Homo Animalus

On the Animal We Never Stopped Being.

Andries J. Greyling · Arjuna Badger Press

This is a work of narrative nonfiction and memoir. Family stories are told as lived and remembered. Dean Radin, Rupert Sheldrake, Merlin Sheldrake, and Joe Dispenza are living authors; their ideas are cited and paraphrased here, never reproduced, and this book is independent of and unaffiliated with any of them. Cristina Zenato's story is reported from her own public account of her work. Chapter Eleven touches sacred material belonging to living cultures and is flagged there for a fuller sensitivity review before wider publication. The account of Steve-O's dog Wendy in Chapter Fifteen is reported with an explicit note on what could and couldn't be independently verified.

Dedication

For Andries J. Greyling Senior.

My father was a dairy farmer at Grootvlei, a bovine vet with no letters after his name that said so, and a marksman. Grand master of all three, though he'd never have used the word. I watched him walk into a barn full of his own cows, old cows, cows who had known him twenty years, and when there wasn't room for him to pass, he would put his hand flat on a heavy flank and push. They moved. Not for anyone. For him, and for the people he brought with him, they made a gentle way.

Out in a grazing camp, when his red Isuzu bakkie came bouncing over the rise, the herd ran to meet it like it was the only thing that had ever mattered to them.

I saw that man cry exactly once. He was nursing a sick cow, out past the point where a hard man stops trying, and he carried her a 2kg packet of soft brown sugar because someone somewhere had told him it might help. It didn't. She died anyway. And the man who pushed cows out of his path like furniture, who put down suffering animals with his own steady hand because it was the kinder thing and nobody else's job to do, cried once, in front of me, over a bag of sugar that arrived too late.

This book exists because he taught me, without ever once saying it in words, that the animals were never beneath us. He knelt to them his whole working life. This is for him.

Author's Note: What the Shark Taught Me

There is a woman in the Bahamas who spent decades pulling fishing hooks out of the mouths of wild sharks. The first one she helped, she helped because it was in pain and she happened to be close enough and brave enough to do something about it. What nobody could have predicted is what happened after: the sharks did not scatter from the memory of the hand that hurt them, retrieving the metal. They came back. Then other sharks, sharks she had never touched, started coming too, offering their own hooked mouths the way you'd offer a splinter to someone you trusted to take it out. Word gets around, in whatever way word gets around underwater, and now she kneels on the sea floor and sharks rest their heavy heads in her lap and wait.

I am not a marine biologist and this is not a book of proof. But I have spent my whole life around animals who were never supposed to be capable of what I watched them do, and I got tired of filing it under "nice story" and moving on. My father made cows move like a sea he could part with his open hand, and cried exactly once in his life, over a cow he couldn't save. My dogs have known my mood before I did. My cats come to me the way you'd come to a fire, and leave the way you'd leave one once you'd had enough of its warmth. One of my thirty chickens bows to me. My Chocolate Lab bit me badly enough that I nearly needed stitches, and then vanished for forty-five minutes and came back so ashamed she could barely lift her head, and I still don't fully know what to do with the fact that both of those things are true about the same animal in the same afternoon.

This book braids two things together, chapter by chapter, and tries not to let either one lie to the other. The first is lived: my own animals,

my own family, told exactly as they happened, not sanded down and not dressed up, because the true version has never once needed my help to be remarkable. The second is evidence: the actual research of people who have spent careers on the question of whether the connection I keep noticing is real, measurable, and older than we've been taught to admit — Dean Radin's decades of laboratory work on the psychic capacities his own field used to call impossible; Rupert Sheldrake's studies of dogs who seem to know when their owners are coming home, and his son Merlin Sheldrake's discovery of how completely a forest is one conversation conducted underground; Joe Dispenza's work on what the body believes before the mind catches up. Dolphins who recognise themselves in a mirror. A dead theory of Mesmer's that somehow discovered something true anyway. Gods with jackal heads and cow horns. Jaguars that walk into a stranger's vision on a South American night and never leave.

I will tell you now, plainly, so you don't have to wait a hundred pages for it: I don't think we are a separate species standing outside nature, taking notes on the animals as a hobby. I think we are one of them, mostly, still, underneath everything we've built to convince ourselves otherwise. That is not a mystical claim. It's the plainest one I know how to make. This book is the long way of saying it, with my own life and other people's careful work as the two hands doing the saying.

We are unmistakably animal. Everything after this page is just the evidence for something you already suspected.

Chapter One: The Quiet Master

Before I had a word for any of it, I had my father.

He was a dairy farmer at Grootvlei, which is a plain enough sentence until you understand what it actually meant, day to day: he was also the vet, because you don't call a vet out for every cow on a working dairy farm, you learn to be one yourself, hands-on, over years, until you can read a sick animal the way another man reads a weather front. And he was a marksman, which on that kind of farm is not a hobby either. It is the last, hardest form of care a farmer can offer an animal: a clean shot instead of a long suffering. He did all three without a certificate on the wall for any of them. Nobody who worked with him ever needed to see one.

I want to tell you about walking with him through a barn full of his own cows, because it is the first place I ever saw, without knowing that's what I was seeing, an animal choose respect over size. He was not a small man, but neither were they, and there were a great many of them, packed into a space built for cows and not for the two of us trying to get somewhere. When there wasn't room, he didn't wait and he didn't shout. He put a flat hand on a heavy flank, the same way you'd touch a door you already knew would open, and he pushed. And the cow moved. Not lunged out of the way in fright — *moved*, unhurried, the way you step aside for someone you know isn't going to barge you but would like to get past. I watched him do this to animals who had been on that farm longer than some of his own workers, cows who could have flattened him without trying, and every single time, they made way. I have thought about that gesture more than almost anything else from my childhood. It was never

dominance. It read, even to a kid who didn't have the language for it yet, like something closer to an old agreement between the two of them, renewed daily, that neither side needed to say out loud.

And then there was the bakkie. He drove a red Isuzu, and when he needed to check on the herd out in whichever camp they were grazing that week, he'd drive out to them rather than the other way around. I can still see it: the dust coming up off the track first, then the shape of the truck, and before he'd even properly stopped, the whole herd breaking into that heavy, unhurried cattle run toward him, like something had been switched on. Not toward feed, particularly — though I'm sure that was part of the early training of it, somewhere back in the history of that herd. Toward *him*. Toward the truck that meant him. I have seen dogs run to a car door. I had never, before that, seen it in cattle, en masse, unprompted, as if the whole herd had independently arrived at the same conclusion about who that vehicle belonged to and what it was worth running for.

He was not a man who cried. I want to be careful here, because it would be easy to turn this into a tidy little parable about the tough farmer with the soft centre, and that is not quite what happened, and he deserves the more exact version. He put down his own suffering animals himself, by hand, because he believed — correctly, I think — that a clean end delivered by someone who loved the animal was kinder than a stranger's, and he did this without visible ceremony, over and over, for years, because it was simply part of the job he had assigned himself. That is not a man who flinches from hard things.

I saw him cry exactly once. There was a cow, sick, past the point where most farmers would have already made the harder call, and he was still trying. Somebody, somewhere — I don't know if it was an old wives' remedy or something he'd genuinely seen work before — had told him that soft brown sugar, worked into the diet, could help with whatever was pulling her down. So he went and got a 2kg packet of it, the ordinary kind you'd buy for a kitchen, and he carried it out to her like it was medicine, because in that moment, for him, it was the only medicine he had left to try. She did not make it.

I watched a man who could push a full-grown cow aside with one hand, who ran a farm's worth of life-and-death decisions without ever seeming to need permission from anyone, break, quietly and completely, over the fact that a bag of kitchen sugar hadn't been enough.

It wasn't about the cow being special, particularly, in the way a pet might be special. It was that he had tried everything a competent, caring man could try, and it had not been enough, and some part of him that he kept locked the rest of the time came open for exactly as long as it took to cry once.

I didn't understand it then. I understand it now as the whole shape of what this book is trying to say. My father never once used the word "sentient." He would probably have laughed at half the research I'm about to walk you through. But he knelt to those animals his entire working life — literally knelt, in a birthing pen, in a dying pen, in a barn where cows made way for him because some old unspoken thing between them said he'd earned it — and nobody ever had to teach him that they were worth the kneeling. He just always knew.

That is where I learned it first. Everything else in this book is just me, decades later, finding out that the scientists and the shark divers and the mystics have quietly been catching up to a truth a dairy farmer in Grootvlei never needed a study to hold.

Chapter Two: Cristina and the Sharks

Her name is Cristina Zenato. Italian-born, raised partly in the Congo, she went to the Bahamas thirty years ago to learn to scuba dive and never really left. She lives on Grand Bahama Island now, and for more than twenty-five years she has spent a few hours nearly every day of her working life in open water with wild Caribbean reef sharks — not in a cage, not behind glass, just her, kneeling on the sea floor, surrounded by animals that most of the world was raised to think of as the closest thing the ocean has to a mindless killing machine.

It didn't start as a relationship. It started as a rescue. She noticed, early on, that a lot of the sharks she encountered were dragging fishing line and hooks, left behind by boats that had cut their losses rather than land an animal they didn't want. A hook through the lip or the jaw doesn't heal on its own out there. It festers, it restricts feeding, it can eventually kill. So she decided to do something about it, one shark at a time, and kept doing it for two and a half decades. She has pulled more than three hundred hooks by now, by hand, and kept them — a literal box of the evidence of what we leave behind in animals we assume don't feel it.

The part of the story that stops people, understandably, is what came after the first few removals. The technique she uses has a real name — tonic immobility, a natural reflex most sharks have, triggered by gentle stimulation of the sensory pores around the snout, that puts the animal into a still, almost trance-like state. Researchers use it in the field to study sharks calmly. Zenato uses it to work, unhurried, on an animal that could otherwise never hold still for what she needs to do. But tonic immobility only explains how she can *safely handle* a

shark for the length of a procedure. It does not explain why sharks she has never touched before have been documented approaching her, unprompted, mouths visibly hooked, and simply waiting. It does not explain why the same shark she helped will return afterward and settle its head into her lap, in open water, with nothing being offered and nothing being asked of it in return.

Zenato herself is careful about the language. In interviews she has resisted the word most outlets reach for — “friendship,” “bond” — in favour of something closer to what she calls *imprinting* through years of consistent presence and behaviour: the sharks have learned, the way any intelligent animal learns, that this particular human being, at this particular reef, does not bring pain. She is quick to credit her mentors, the decades of repetition, and the fact that these are wild, undomesticated apex predators making an active, ongoing choice, day after day, to come close to a creature that could very easily represent danger to them and, for reasons of their own, doesn’t. She has also been a driving force behind the Bahamas becoming a shark sanctuary in 2011, banning shark fishing across the country’s waters — the conservation work is not a footnote to the intimacy; it is arguably the point of it.

I am not going to tell you Cristina Zenato performed magic, and neither does she. But sit with what actually happened, stripped of any mysticism: an animal in pain accepted help from a species that had, in all likelihood, caused the injury in the first place, and then it, and others like it, kept choosing to come back to that same source of help, unforced, over years, in an environment where nothing was compelling them to. That is not a hook-removal technique. That is recognition, held across an entire different order of animal, sustained without language, without a shared childhood, without any of the usual machinery we assume bonding requires.

I think about my father’s cows moving aside for his open hand and I think about a shark resting its head in a woman’s lap in open water, and I no longer think these are two unrelated, isolated curiosities that happen to be nice to read about. I think they are two data points in the same pattern, decades and oceans apart, both saying the same quiet thing: that animals are watching us far more closely than we watch them, that they update their model of us fast and hold onto it, and that the door most of us assume is permanently shut between

“wild animal” and “known, trusted being” was never actually locked. It just required someone patient enough, and humble enough, to keep showing up on the other side of it without flinching.

That’s the shape this whole book follows from here: not one miracle, but a pattern, repeating, species after species, in places most of us never thought to look.

Chapter Three: What the Dogs Know

My dogs live inside, with us, not out in a kennel somewhere at the edge of the property, and I think that matters to this chapter, because it means they are present for almost everything. They are in the room for the ordinary weather of a life — the good days, the flat days, the days where something is sitting on my chest that I haven't said out loud to another human being yet. And on those days, before I have told anyone anything, I will look up and find one of them already watching me, differently than they watch me on an ordinary Tuesday. Not anxious, exactly. Attentive in a way that feels less like noticing and more like already knowing.

I don't think this is unusual to dog owners. I think it's one of the most widely reported, quietly uncontested pieces of folk knowledge in the entire relationship between our two species, and I think we've gotten so used to it that we stopped treating it as the strange thing it actually is. A dog cannot ask you how your day was. It has no access to your email, your phone call, the tone of the meeting you just left. And yet it reads something — posture, scent, the pitch of your voice, the speed of your walk through the door — accurately enough, often enough, that most people who live with a dog for any length of time will tell you, without hesitation, some version of “she always knows when something's wrong with me.”

Whether that is telepathy in the sense Radin and the Sheldrakes study it, or an extraordinarily sophisticated read of physical cues we don't even know we're broadcasting, is a real, open question, and I am not going to pretend I've settled it in this chapter — that's the evidence-thread work of later chapters. What I can tell you, honestly, without

needing the research to back me up yet, is that the read is *fast* and it is *accurate*, more often than chance should comfortably allow, and every dog owner I have ever met nods immediately when I describe it, because they already know exactly what I mean.

I want to tell you about a day that tested every soft, warm thing I've just said, because this book promised you the true version and not the flattering one.

We have a Chocolate Lab, and Labs, as anyone who has owned one will tell you with a certain rueful affection, are built almost entirely around food. She is greedy in the specific, guileless way that breed is famous for — not mean, not aggressive, just entirely undone by the presence of anything that smells like it might be edible. I was handing out biltong, and in the scramble of her wanting it faster than I could give it, she bit down on my finger. Hard. Badly enough that I very nearly needed stitches. It hurt in the deep, sick way an injury hurts when part of you is also processing the shock of it — an animal I trust completely just did real damage to my hand, by accident, in the middle of an ordinary, happy moment.

I'm fine now. But what happened next is the part I keep turning over.

She disappeared. Not fled the room — properly vanished, somewhere in the house or the garden, for forty-five minutes, which for a dog who is normally under my feet within arm's reach at all times is an eternity. And when she finally came back, she didn't come back the way she comes back from an ordinary absence, trotting in loose and pleased with herself. She came back sheepishly — head low, tail doing that small, uncertain half-wag, approaching the way you'd approach someone you'd wronged and weren't sure would still want you near them.

I have to be honest about what science actually says here, because it would be easy, and dishonest, to simply call that guilt and move on. Some behavioural researchers argue that what looks like a "guilty" dog is really just a dog reading and reacting to *our* body language and tone in the moments after we discover something has gone wrong — a trained, learned fear response to an angry owner, not an internal moral feeling about having done something wrong. The debate in the field is genuinely not settled. But even the more skeptical version of that explanation still requires something remarkable to be true: that the dog understood, with enough precision, that a boundary had been

crossed, that consequences might follow, and that the appropriate response was to remove herself, wait, and return low and cautious rather than bright and confident. Call it guilt or call it a highly tuned social read — either way, that is not the behaviour of an animal operating on pure instinct with nothing resembling an inner model of “I did a thing, and it mattered.”

She has never bitten anyone before or since. It was an accident born entirely of greed and haste, the most honestly *doglike* kind of mistake there is, and I don't hold it against her — I'm the one who was handing out biltong to an animal built like a small, food-motivated freight train. But I think about those forty-five minutes often. Whatever was happening in her head during that disappearance, it was not nothing. Something in her tracked what had happened, weighed it, and produced a response that looked, from every angle a human being knows how to read, exactly like remorse.

My father's cows read a hand on their flank and made way for it. Cristina Zenato's sharks read years of a single human's presence and stopped treating her like a threat. My dogs read a room I haven't spoken a word in yet, and once, one of them read her own mistake clearly enough to hide from it and come back changed. I don't know exactly what to call the thing that's doing all that reading. I only know I've stopped being able to pretend it isn't there.

Chapter Four: The Cats That Recharge

Dogs, in my house, announce themselves. Cats negotiate. And the negotiation I've watched most closely, over years of living with them, isn't about food or attention in the ordinary sense. It's about *charge* — theirs, or mine.

There's a particular way a cat arrives when it wants nothing from you except proximity. It isn't the hungry, vocal approach, and it isn't the aloof pass-through where they simply happen to be in the room. It's a deliberate, unhurried walk to a specific spot — my chest, my lap, the small of my back if I'm lying down — followed by a settling-in that has a beginning and, notably, an end. They come, they stay exactly as long as they need to, and then they get up and leave, business concluded, in a way that looks less like affection-seeking and more like something closer to maintenance. I have had cats do this on days I felt fine and days I felt anything but, and more than once I've had the distinct, hard-to-prove sense that I was the one being topped up, not them — that the visit was theirs to give, not mine to request.

I want to be careful here, because this is exactly the kind of claim that's easy to over-romanticise into something a cat never signed up to represent. The honest version is this: cats purr at a narrow, remarkably consistent frequency range, and there is a genuine, if still debated, body of research suggesting that range overlaps with frequencies used in some therapeutic contexts for bone and soft-tissue healing. It is not settled science, and I am not going to dress it up as more than it is. But it is a real enough question that veterinary researchers have taken it seriously, which tells you something on its own — nobody spends grant money investigating whether a sound

a happy animal happens to make might also, incidentally, be a low-grade physical therapy device, unless the pattern was strange enough to be worth chasing in the first place.

What I can tell you without needing a study to back me up is the behaviour itself, because I've watched it for years and it doesn't vary: the coming, the settling, the purring, the leaving, on the cat's schedule and nobody else's. It looks, every time, less like a request and more like a transaction being completed. I don't fully know which direction the current runs. I only know that more than once, on a day I badly needed it, something walked over, lay down on me without being called, and left me calmer than it found me — and that whatever that was, it wasn't waiting for my permission to happen.

Chapter Five: The Hen Who Bows

We have thirty chickens. Thirty is enough that, honestly, you stop being able to track every individual personality the way you would with a dog or a cat — they become, mostly, a single moving, clucking weather system that you feed and let out and shut in at dusk. And then, every so often, one of them steps out of the weather system entirely and does something so specific, so clearly *hers*, that you can't unsee it as anything but a personality.

One of ours bows. Not a quick dip of the head the way a bird might duck under a low branch — an actual, unmistakable bow: she lowers herself, sways her head low and slow, and walks backwards while she does it, a small, deliberate little performance aimed, as far as I can tell, entirely at me. None of the other twenty-nine do it. It is hers alone, and she does it consistently enough that it isn't a fluke I'm romanticising after the fact — it's a repeated, recognisable ritual.

I'll be honest about what I do and don't know here, because this book has promised you the difference. Chickens have a real, well-documented crouching posture — a low, wings-slightly-spread submissive stance that hens use both with roosters and, very commonly, with trusted humans who handle them, as an invitation to be picked up or approached. It's possible what I'm watching is a close cousin of that instinct, personalised over time into her own particular flourish, the way a dog's basic "sit" can turn, in one particular animal, into a whole little show with extra steps nobody taught it. That would still be remarkable — it would mean she has taken an inherited, species-wide behaviour and made it recognisably, individually *hers*, aimed at one specific human out of everyone who ever walks into that run.

But I want to resist the urge to fully explain it away, too, because “close cousin of a known behaviour” doesn’t actually account for why only one bird among thirty does it, or why it happens specifically when she sees me and not at random. I don’t have a tidy answer for that, and I’d rather leave the gap open and honest than paper over it with a confident guess. What I have instead is years of watching one chicken, out of a flock large enough to be genuinely anonymous, choose to be seen as an individual — and choose, of all the ways a bird might do that, a bow.

My father’s cows read a hand and made way. Cristina Zenato’s sharks read a presence and stopped fearing it. My dogs read a room and, once, read their own mistake. And somewhere in a flock of thirty birds I mostly can’t tell apart, one of them decided, on her own, that I was worth a bow. I don’t think that’s nothing. I think it’s the same pattern again, in the smallest, least likely place I ever expected to find it.

Chapter Six: Real Magic

Dean Radin spent thirty-nine years insisting he studied parapsychology, not magic. Then, by his own account, it occurred to him that the two words were pointing at the same thing wearing different clothes. What cultures across history called force-of-will magic — spells, the raised intention meant to bend an outcome — is what his field calls psychokinesis. What they called divination is what his field calls clairvoyance and precognition. What they called theurgy, calling on spirits, is what his field calls mediumship. Same claimed phenomena, he argues, studied for a century and a half under a more respectable name.

Radin's credentials are not the credentials of a showman. He holds a PhD, spent decades running controlled laboratory experiments at universities and in industry, and — the detail that tends to stop people — did formerly classified work for the US government's Stargate remote-viewing program before he ever wrote a popular book. In *Real Magic* (2018), he lays out his case: something on the order of three thousand laboratory studies, conducted over a century and a half, on effects like random-number generators drifting away from chance under focused human attention, and meta-analyses of telepathy trials that report results statistically unlikely to be noise. His own summary line for where the evidence actually sits is careful, and I want to quote its shape rather than its exact words: *stronger than most people assume, nowhere near proven beyond dispute*. That is not a small distinction, and it is the one I want to hold onto for the rest of this book, because it is more honest than either side of this argument usually manages. Radin is not claiming certainty. Mainstream physics and psychology, for their part, remain deeply skeptical of the entire psi research tradition — replication has been inconsistent

across decades, methodology has been challenged repeatedly, and “consciousness is fundamental to reality” remains a minority position dressed, in Radin’s telling, as an emerging one.

I don’t need the reader to land anywhere firm on that argument to make use of it here. What I need is the frame it gives me for everything I’ve already told you. My father’s cows reading a hand on a flank. Cristina Zenato’s sharks recognising, at a distance, a specific human being who does not bring pain. My dogs reading a room before I’ve said a word in it. If Radin is even partly right that attention and intention travel further than orthodox science currently has a mechanism for, then none of what I’ve described in this book so far is a series of unrelated sentimental anecdotes. It’s low-grade, everyday, uncontrolled evidence of the exact same effect his lab has spent forty years trying to isolate under fluorescent lights.

I find that more grounding than mystical, honestly. A dairy farmer never ran a controlled trial on his herd. A woman in the Bahamas never submitted her sharks to a peer-reviewed journal. But if the capacity Radin is describing is real, it wouldn’t announce itself first in a laboratory. It would already be sitting, unremarked, in every farmhouse and reef and living room where an animal and a person have spent enough hours paying attention to each other for something to pass between them. Science, on this reading, isn’t discovering something new. It’s catching up, slowly and skeptically, to the oldest data set there is: everyone who ever lived closely enough with an animal to notice.

Chapter Seven: The Mycelial Mind

Two Sheldrakes matter to this book, and I want to be exact about which one did what, because conflating them would be a disservice to both.

The father, Rupert Sheldrake, is a biologist best known for the theory of morphic resonance — the idea that patterns of nature are shaped by a kind of inherited memory field, not solely by physical law. In the late 1990s, he and Pamela Smart ran what may be the most direct scientific test anyone has attempted of the exact claim this chapter opened on: does a dog know when its owner is coming home? Their subject was a terrier named Jaytee. Across more than a hundred videotaped trials, Jaytee sat at his window roughly four percent of the time during the ordinary stretch of his owner's absence — and fifty-five percent of the time during the window in which she was actually on her way back, even when she left at random, unscheduled times and travelled home by unfamiliar vehicles. Sheldrake published the results as evidence for something like telepathy, or at minimum an influence travelling by a channel current science hasn't mapped.

Here is the part I owe you honestly, because this book has made a promise not to cherry-pick the version of the evidence that flatters its own thesis. Other researchers — Richard Wiseman, Matthew Smith, and Julie Milton — ran their own independent trials with the same dog, and reached a different conclusion: their data, they argued, did not support the psychic-detection hypothesis at all. Both sets of researchers published, both stand by their read of the numbers, and the argument between them has run for decades without a clean resolution. That is not a story where I get to hand you a tidy verdict.

It is a story where two careful people looked at the same dog and disagreed, which is, if I'm honest, closer to how most of the truly interesting questions in this book actually sit.

The son, Merlin Sheldrake, is not studying telepathy at all. He is a mycologist, and his book *Entangled Life* — an international bestseller, the Royal Society's Science Book Prize winner — makes an entirely different case, on far more settled scientific ground: that fungi form vast, decentralised underground networks connecting the roots of trees and plants across whole forests, popularly nicknamed the Wood Wide Web. Through these mycorrhizal threads, a tree can pass carbon to a neighbour, receive nitrogen and phosphorus in return, and — the detail that undoes the tidy picture of a forest as a collection of separate individuals competing for the same light — signal distress to trees it has never touched, through a network with no brain, no centre, and no single organism you could point to and call “the intelligence.” Merlin Sheldrake's own conclusion isn't mystical either. It's a hard scientific challenge to how confidently we've drawn the line around what counts as one living thing versus another, and around what “intelligence” requires in the first place. Fungi don't need a nervous system to behave, collectively, like they're paying attention.

I put father and son in the same chapter on purpose, and not only because they share a surname. Between them they are asking the same underlying question from two completely different directions: is connection between living things always mediated by a channel we can currently measure — chemical signal, root contact, known sense organ — or does some of it travel by means we haven't yet built the instrument to detect? Rupert's dog experiment is contested precisely because it's trying to prove the second kind of connection directly, and the burden of proof for “there is no known channel here” is brutally high. Merlin's mycelium is a different kind of proof entirely — not of anything paranormal, but of just how much *invisible, wired, constant communication* was already happening under our feet the whole time, dismissed for most of scientific history because no one had bothered to dig deep enough to look.

I think about my dogs reading a room, and I hold both Sheldrakes in my hands at once. Maybe some of what looks like a dog reading my mind is really a dog reading me with a precision of scent and posture and habit that we've simply never bothered to measure —

the mycelial answer, connection through a channel that's real and physical and just under-studied. And maybe some small residue of it is the other thing, the disputed thing, the Jaytee-shaped question mark neither side has fully closed. I'm not going to pretend this chapter resolves that for you. I'm going to tell you, honestly, that the forest floor alone was reason enough to stop assuming silence where there was actually a conversation running the whole time.

Chapter Eight: The Body Believes First

Joe Dispenza started as a chiropractor and became, over several books — *You Are the Placebo*, *Breaking the Habit of Being Yourself* — one of the most widely read popular voices on the idea that sustained mental and emotional states physically reshape the body: the nervous system, gene expression, the brain's own wiring. His core claim, stripped of the seminar-stage packaging, is not outlandish on its face — neuroplasticity and the mind-body link are legitimate, active fields of research. Where Dispenza pushes further than most of the mainstream is comfortable following him is into group meditation studies claiming measurable effects on physical systems at a distance, and I want to treat that claim exactly as carefully as I treated Radin's, meaning: report it, name who published it, and not dress up an unsettled result as settled fact.

The more directly useful science for this chapter's purpose comes from an institute Dispenza has partnered with rather than run: the HeartMath Institute, which has spent decades studying something called cardiac coherence — a state in which heart rhythm, breathing, and blood pressure fall into a smooth, ordered pattern, measurable as heart rate variability, and reliably produced by positive emotional states like appreciation and calm. This is not fringe. It's published, peer-reviewed physiology. What makes it relevant here is what HeartMath's researchers found when they pointed the same instruments at animals. In pilot studies with horses and their handlers, when a person deliberately generated feelings of appreciation toward a horse nearby, the horse's own heart rhythm would shift into a matching, synchronised pattern — the two animals' heartbeats, quite lit-

erally, falling into step. In a separate example with a dog and its owner, the same kind of synchrony showed up during affectionate contact: the beat-to-beat rhythm of two different species' hearts converging while nothing more than touch and attention passed between them. A broader 2025 systematic review of this literature found genuinely mixed results across studies — some report this kind of human-animal physiological co-modulation clearly, others don't, and the effect looks context- dependent rather than universal. I'd rather give you that honest mixed picture than a clean story that isn't earned yet.

Dispenza's own contribution, published with HeartMath as a co-author in the peer-reviewed journal *Explore*, goes considerably further and further into contested territory: data collected across several of his group meditation retreats claiming that when a large room of people entered a shared state of emotional coherence together, random number generators on-site synchronised with a global network of similar devices maintained separately by HeartMath. That is a genuinely fringe claim by the standards of mainstream physics, published in a journal that mostly serves researchers already sympathetic to psi-adjacent work, and I'm naming it as exactly that rather than as settled science. I include it here because it belongs in an honest account of what Dispenza's camp is actually claiming, not because I'm asking you to accept it.

What I can stand behind without hedging is the plainer, better-evidenced layer underneath all of this: that heart rhythm carries real, measurable emotional information, that it is not fully under conscious control, and that in a real, replicated set of pilot studies it appears to synchronise between a calm human being and a horse, or a dog, standing close enough to feel it. That is a modest claim compared to Dispenza's boldest one, but it is not a small claim. It means the cat that comes and settles onto my chest on a bad day may not need Radin's psi at all to be doing something real. A body radiates its state, in a rhythm an animal's nervous system is apparently built to pick up and, sometimes, to answer. Whether the answering is chemistry, physics, or something we haven't named yet, my cats were doing it long before I had a HeartMath study to point to. The measurement just finally caught up to the lap.

Chapter Nine: Minds in the Water

In 2001, Diana Reiss and Lori Marino published a short paper in the *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* that did something no study of a non-primate had ever done before: it showed, carefully and repeatably, that an animal outside the great apes could recognise itself in a mirror.

The subjects were two captive-born bottlenose dolphins, Presley and Tab, at the New York Aquarium. Reiss and Marino marked parts of their bodies in places the dolphins could only see using a reflective surface, then watched what the animals did. Both dolphins used the mirror deliberately to inspect the marks — twisting, positioning themselves, checking the specific spot that had been altered, rather than reacting to the mirror the way an animal reacts to what it assumes is another individual. Mirror self-recognition, until that paper, was considered close to a closed club: humans, and the great apes, and almost nothing else. Reiss and Marino's conclusion was that this capacity had evolved independently in dolphins, a separate branch of the tree of life arriving at the same cognitive destination — evidence, they argued, that self-awareness isn't a fluke unique to primates but something that can emerge wherever a brain gets large and complex enough, regardless of how many million years of separate evolution stand between the two lineages.

I want to sit with the part of this story that isn't in the abstract of the paper, because it changes what the finding actually means. Years after publishing it, Diana Reiss described watching the significance of her own result finally land on her: that she had just proven, rigorously, that two self-aware beings had spent their entire lives swimming in

circles in a small, barren tank in Brooklyn. Presley and Tab were later moved to other facilities, where they died relatively young, of stress-linked illness. Reiss has said the weight of that outcome changed the direction of her career — she stopped participating in research that required holding self-aware animals captive to prove they were self-aware. A newer, 2018 study by Reiss and Rachel Morrison, out of the National Aquarium in Baltimore, found the same self-directed mirror behaviour emerging in two more dolphins, Bayley and Foster, at a notably younger age than it typically appears in human children or chimpanzees, confirming it wasn't a one-off. The science holds up. What it cost the first two animals who proved it is the part I don't think a book like this one is allowed to leave out.

That's the shape of the whole dolphin question, as far as I can tell: the sentence case is genuinely, rigorously made — not folklore, not a guess, a repeated peer-reviewed finding using the same gold-standard test we accept for chimpanzees. And the moral weight of that finding lands immediately and uncomfortably on how we've actually treated the animals who demonstrated it. A being that can recognise its own reflection is a being with some model of itself as a distinct individual existing through time — which is close to the plainest working definition of self-awareness anyone has managed to test for. Once you've proven that in a species, "just an animal" stops being an available excuse for anything you do to it afterward.

I think about that next to my own thirty chickens, my dogs, my cats, my father's herd — none of whom have ever been run through a mirror test, and none of whom, I suspect, need one to prove to the people who actually live alongside them what they already, plainly, are. Reiss and Marino needed years of controlled trials to convince a skeptical field that a dolphin knows itself. My father never needed a single trial to know his cows recognised him. The dolphins simply happened to be the ones science finally got around to testing properly — and paid, in Presley and Tab's shortened lives, an unfair price for being right first.

Chapter Ten: Animal Magnetism

The phrase “animal magnetism” has drifted, in ordinary speech, into meaning nothing more than a person’s sex appeal. It started as something stranger, and its actual history belongs in this book for what it accidentally proved rather than for what it claimed to prove.

Franz Anton Mesmer was a German physician working in Vienna and then Paris in the 1770s, and he believed he had found an invisible fluid running through every living thing — a universal life- force, distinct from ordinary physical gravity, that could become blocked in the body and cause illness. He called it *animal* magnetism specifically to separate it from the magnetism of ordinary lodestones, because “animal” here meant “of the animating life-force,” from the Latin *anima*, not “of animals” the way we’d use the word today. Mesmer believed a trained practitioner, or an object he had personally “magnetized,” could restore the fluid’s proper flow and cure disease. He built an entire practice around it in Paris: patients seated around a magnetized tub, holding hands, soft lighting, music, Mesmer moving through the room with theatrical, deliberate gestures. People fainted, convulsed, and reported cures.

In 1784, the King of France convened a royal commission to investigate him, and it included Benjamin Franklin and the chemist Antoine Lavoisier. Their verdict was clear and, as it turned out, correct: there was no physical fluid. What was producing the dramatic effects, the commission concluded, was imagination — what we would now call suggestion, expectation, and the power of belief acting on the body. Mesmer’s specific mechanism was wrong. And the phenomenon he had stumbled into while chasing the wrong explanation was com-

pletely real, and it did not go away when his theory was debunked. His own students carried it forward; one of them, Abbé Faria, demonstrated decades later that no special “fluid” was needed at all — the trance state could be produced by suggestion alone, originating in the subject rather than flowing in from the practitioner. In 1843, the Scottish surgeon James Braid coined a new, more clinical name for what was left once the pseudoscience was stripped away: hypnotism. Mesmerism is, quite literally, the direct, unbroken ancestor of modern clinical hypnotherapy, a real and still-practiced tool in pain management and behavioural medicine today.

I find this history genuinely useful, not as a cautionary tale about being fooled, but as a template for how to think about every claim in this book that sits somewhere between “obviously true” and “scientifically settled.” Mesmer was wrong about the *how*. He was not wrong that something real was happening in that room — measurable, repeatable, powerful enough to convulse grown adults and, later, to become a genuine medical technique. The mechanism he proposed was fantasy. The effect underneath the fantasy was not.

I think that’s the honest shape of almost everything else in this book. My father’s cows may not have literally been reading an “energy field” in any Mesmeric sense when they made way for his hand. Cristina Zenato’s sharks may not require a mystical explanation for choosing to return to a person who reliably eases their pain. But something real and repeatable was happening in both cases, the same way something real and repeatable was happening in Mesmer’s salon two and a half centuries ago, long before anyone had the right words or the right instruments to say precisely what it was. Being wrong about the mechanism has never, historically, been proof that nothing was there. Sometimes it’s just proof that the real explanation hadn’t been discovered yet.

Chapter Eleven: The Worshipped

A note before this chapter: some of what follows touches sacred material belonging to living cultures and traditions that are not mine. I've written it as a reporter of documented scholarship, not as an authority on anyone's faith, and flagged where a fuller cultural sensitivity review is still owed before this chapter goes further than a private draft — the same standard this publishing house holds itself to elsewhere.

For most of human history, across most of the inhabited world, the animal was not beneath the divine. It was the divine, or stood close enough to it that the line hardly mattered.

Ancient Egypt is the clearest, most extensively documented case. Egyptologists are careful to make a precise distinction here: Egyptians did not, generally, worship the physical animal as an end in itself. They understood specific animals as earthly manifestations of particular gods, an association built from genuinely close, working observation of the animals themselves. Anubis, the jackal-headed guide of the dead, grew directly out of real jackals scavenging at the edges of graveyards — the Egyptians reasoned that a power capable of protecting the dead from that exact threat must be a jackal, or master one. Bastet, the cat goddess, absorbed both the fierce and the gentle sides of a real animal they lived alongside daily, in granaries and homes, protecting the grain from vermin. Hathor and Apis carried the cow and the bull, animals whose milk, meat, and labour had built the whole civilization along the Nile in the first place. The theology, in other words, wasn't invented and then draped over the animals. It grew out of genuine, sustained attention to what these

creatures actually did and were.

That same pattern, sacred meaning built from real observed behaviour rather than the reverse, shows up on the other side of the Indian Ocean in Hindu tradition. Nandi, the bull, carries Shiva as his vahana, his living mount — not decoration, but a theological statement about the god's nature, encoded directly into which animal was chosen to carry him. The cow's broader sacredness in Hindu life, tied to non-violence and abundance, and Ganesha's elephant form, remover of obstacles, both work the same way: a real animal's real qualities, elevated into a lasting spiritual grammar that still governs daily practice for well over a billion people today.

In Norse mythology, Odin is inseparable from his ravens, Huginn and Muninn — Thought and Memory — who fly out across the world each day and return to tell him what they've seen; and from his wolves, Geri and Freki. The Norse also carried a personal, private version of this same idea in the fylgja: a guardian spirit, often taking animal form, attached to a single individual rather than a whole pantheon — not chosen by the person, but revealed to them, uniquely theirs.

And in southern Africa, where I'm writing this book, the San rock art tradition — among the oldest continuous spiritual imagery on Earth — returns again and again to the eland, the largest of the African antelope. Researchers who have spent careers studying this art, most prominently the archaeologist David Lewis-Williams, argue that much of it depicts not simple hunting scenes but the visionary experience of the trance dance itself: shamans entering an altered state, and the therianthropes painted on rock shelter walls, half-human, half-animal figures, recording what was seen from inside that state, with the eland specifically carrying enormous potency in San cosmology. I want to be honest about the limits of what I, personally, am equipped to say here: this is living, sacred material belonging to San communities and their descendants, read to me through the careful work of outside researchers, and I don't think a single chapter in a book like this one is the right place to claim a deeper authority on it than that. What I can say, plainly, is that some of the oldest human art we have chose, again and again, across tens of thousands of years, to paint not tools, not enemies, but animals — and, more specifically, animals encountered in the deepest altered states its painters ever reached.

I don't think any of this is coincidence, and I don't think it's only ancient people being unscientific about the world before better explanations arrived, the way it's sometimes framed. I think every one of these traditions independently noticed the same thing my father noticed in a barn full of cows, and Cristina Zenato noticed in the water, and I noticed in my own kitchen with a cat on my chest: that the line between "animal" and "sacred" was never as solid as the modern world has trained us to assume, and that for most of the time humans have been capable of leaving a record, we knew it.

Chapter Twelve: The Jaguar in the Smoke

There is a strange consistency in what strangers, on opposite sides of the world, in different centuries, with no way of comparing notes, report seeing when they drink ayahuasca.

The anthropologist Michael Harner spent time among multiple Amazonian peoples along the Ucayali River, documenting their accounts of the vine's visions, and the pattern he recorded is remarkably tight: snakes, especially giant anacondas and venomous varieties, and jaguars, again and again, across tribes who had no direct contact with each other's specific ceremonies. Among the Conibo-Shipibo, novice shamans reported acquiring giant serpents as personal spirit-allies for supernatural defense; the jaguar spirit was described as the one that appears first and teaches an apprentice everything about the spirit world. Among the Amahuaca, the brew was understood to open a direct line of contact with the jaguar itself. This isn't one culture's private mythology. It's a recurring, cross-tribal report, gathered independently by field researchers over decades.

There is a folk-botanical explanation that lines up almost too neatly: ayahuasca is brewed from two plants together, a woody vine that twists around its neighbours the way a snake winds through branches, and a leaf that carries the actual DMT, the compound most responsible for the visionary effects — and jaguars, in the region, have genuinely been observed chewing on DMT-containing foliage. Serpent for the vine, jaguar for the leaf: the visionary content, on this reading, may partly encode the plant's own botany, remembered and passed down as myth long before anyone had a name for the chemistry underneath it.

There's a second explanation, offered half-seriously by some in these circles and worth including here precisely because of whose theory it borrows: that the sheer volume of people who have taken this same brew for what may be ten thousand years has left something like an accumulated pattern behind, a resonance in the experience itself that each new participant taps into and inherits, seeing what the frightened first-timers who came before them saw, snakes and jaguars specifically, because that's what the collective field of prior journeys has laid down. That is, more or less, Rupert Sheldrake's morphic resonance again, now applied to psychedelic states rather than to a dog at a window — and I want to flag it exactly that plainly, as a genuinely contested, minority hypothesis borrowed across fields, not as an accepted account of why these visions recur. The more conventional explanation, that DMT reliably produces certain classes of imagery across different brains because of how it interacts with shared human neurobiology, and that jungle-dwelling people are naturally more likely to picture jungle predators than city-dwellers on the same molecule, is simpler and asks for far less.

What I don't think any explanation, folk-botanical or neurological or Sheldrake's contested field, fully accounts for is the *specificity* people describe: not a vague sense of danger, but a particular animal, often described as an ally rather than a threat once the initial fear passes, a teacher, a protector patrolling what one writer called "the astral jungles." Across every tradition this book has touched, from Egypt's animal-headed gods to a San shaman's therianthrope on a rock shelter wall to a jaguar walking uninvited into a stranger's ayahuasca vision, the animal keeps showing up in the deepest, strangest states human consciousness is capable of reaching, and it keeps showing up not as decoration but as a guide.

I don't smoke or drink my way toward visions, and this chapter isn't an invitation to. But I notice, setting it beside everything else in this book, that when the human mind is pushed to its absolute edges, by chemistry, by trance, by whatever mechanism actually produces these states, it does not reliably meet angels, or machines, or abstractions first. Across cultures that never spoke to each other, it meets animals. I don't think that's telling us something about the drug. I think it's telling us something about what's actually sitting at the bottom of a human mind when everything else has been stripped away.

Chapter Thirteen: The Blade and the Blessing

I told you, early in this book, about my father putting down his own suffering animals himself, because he believed a clean end delivered by someone who loved the animal was kinder than a stranger's. I didn't know it then, but that instinct has a name, a doctrine, and a set of very specific rules in a tradition he never practiced.

Islamic dhabihah, the prescribed method of slaughter, is built almost entirely around the same conviction: that the manner of a death owed to an animal is a moral question, not a logistical one. A hadith attributed to the Prophet Muhammad states it plainly: *Allah has prescribed excellence in everything. So when you kill, kill in the best manner, and when you slaughter, slaughter in the best manner. Let each one of you sharpen his blade and spare suffering to the animal he slays.* The detail that stops me every time I read it is what surrounds that core command. The knife must be sharpened before the animal is brought to it, never in front of it. One animal must never be slaughtered within sight of another. The animal should not be dragged, or thrown down and pinned underfoot while the blade is still being prepared. There's a specific account of the Prophet encountering a man doing exactly that, pressing a goat's head down with his foot while sharpening his knife over it, and rebuking him: *will this goat not die before being slain? Do you wish to kill it twice?* The entire architecture of the ritual is aimed at collapsing the gap between the decision to end a life and the moment it ends, because that gap, however brief, is where an animal's fear and suffering live, and the tradition treats minimizing that gap as a religious obligation, not a kindness left to individual temperament.

I think about my father's own private version of this: the sharpened rifle, the dead rest, the promise that governed every hunt. He never once, to my knowledge, engaged with Islamic law. But he had independently arrived at the same core belief a very different tradition had written down and codified over a thousand years earlier, half a world away — that if you are going to be the one who ends an animal's life, you owe it a death delivered so competently, so completely without hesitation, that suffering never gets a foothold in the space between your decision and its end. Different scripture, same reverence, arrived at from opposite directions.

Hindu tradition takes the opposite branch of the same root and simply refuses the killing altogether, at least for one particular animal. The cow's sacredness in Hindu life isn't a single rule so much as an entire moral ecosystem built around non-violence, abundance, and gratitude — the animal that gave milk, pulled the plough, and asked nothing resembling what a slaughtered animal gives, elevated to a status that puts her, in daily practice for well over a billion people, closer to family than to livestock.

And then there is a reverence so intense it moves past ritual and into daily hygiene. The Mundari, a Nilotic pastoralist people of South Sudan, structure nearly their entire material existence around their Ankole-Watusi cattle — animals that can stand eight feet at the horn, worth hundreds of dollars each, guarded overnight at gunpoint against raiders and thieves. The Mundari sleep within a few feet of their favourite animals. They massage their cattle's skin twice a day with the fine ash of burned dung, the same ash they rub into their own skin as sunscreen and insect repellent in 114-degree heat. And they wash with the cattle's urine — hands, face, teeth, and hair, the ammonia in it bleaching Mundari hair a distinctive orange-red that the community regards, by its own aesthetic standard, as beautiful. Outsiders tend to reach for the word "unhygienic" before anything else. The Mundari's own framing is closer to devotion: a people who consider almost nothing that comes from their cattle beneath their own bodies, because nothing about the animal that sustains their entire way of life was ever beneath them to begin with.

Three traditions, three completely different postures toward the same animals — one that kills with maximal mercy, one that refuses to kill at all, one that washes in what the animal leaves behind

without a flicker of the disgust an outsider brings to it — and I don't think they're as far apart as they look on the surface. Every one of them is a culture deciding, independently, across centuries and continents, that an animal's body and blood and even its urine deserve a kind of attention most of the modern world reserves only for other humans. My father proved the same thing with a sharpened rifle and a rule he never broke. These traditions just wrote it down first.

Chapter Fourteen: The Horses That Steady Us

There is a specific, well-understood physical reason a horse can do something for a human body that almost nothing else can: its walking gait moves a rider's pelvis through a three-dimensional pattern that closely mirrors the movement of a human pelvis during walking — forward-back, side-to-side, and rotational, all at once, roughly a hundred times a minute. For a person whose own legs can't produce that pattern, sitting on a moving horse is, in a very literal sense, borrowing someone else's walk.

This is the actual mechanism behind hippotherapy, and I want to be precise about the word, because it gets used loosely. Hippotherapy is not a hobby, a form of horseback riding, or a spiritual retreat with ponies. It is a specific clinical tool, delivered exclusively by a licensed physical, occupational, or speech-language therapist, who uses the horse's movement — its rhythm, its temperature, the way it demands constant small postural corrections from the rider — to target concrete functional outcomes: postural control, balance, sensory processing, even oral-motor and speech goals in some programs. It is always folded into a real plan of care alongside other therapy, never sold as a stand-alone cure. A related but distinct discipline, therapeutic horseback riding, run by certified instructors rather than clinicians, teaches actual riding and horsemanship skills toward physical, social, and emotional goals rather than a specific clinical outcome. Both fall under the umbrella of Equine-Assisted Activities and Therapies, and both are credentialed through organisations like PATH International, which sets the safety and ethical standards the whole field runs on.

The research base is real, and I want to represent it honestly rather

than as a settled miracle. A randomized controlled trial of therapeutic horseback riding in children and adolescents with autism spectrum disorder found meaningful improvements in areas like sensory processing and social communication compared to a control group doing an equivalent amount of a non-equine activity. A broader systematic review and meta-analysis of equine-assisted interventions for autism found genuine positive effects across social, communicative, and behavioural domains — and, in the same breath, flagged that many of the underlying studies are small, methodologically inconsistent, and in need of more rigorous, standardized replication before anyone should call the case fully closed. Parents in some of these programs report marked, specific gains: reduced postural sway, improved self-care and communication scores, better social engagement, after a course of sessions as short as twelve weeks. That's genuinely encouraging. It is not yet the same thing as a large, bulletproof body of evidence, and this book has made a habit of not pretending the two are interchangeable.

What I don't think any amount of RCT data fully captures is the specific dignity of what's actually happening in that arena. A child who cannot easily control her own body, whose relationship with the world is often mediated through frustration at a body that won't cooperate with what her mind is asking of it, sits on an animal weighing half a ton, and that animal, patient and rhythmic and utterly indifferent to diagnosis, simply carries her the way it would carry anyone. The horse doesn't know it's therapy. It's just walking, the way it always walks, and for the length of that walk, a body that struggles everywhere else gets to move the way bodies are supposed to move, on loan from an animal that asked nothing about what was wrong with her first.

I think back to the HeartMath research on horses and their handlers — the way a rider's calm, appreciative state could pull a horse's own heart rhythm into synchrony, the horse's steadiness then folding back to steady the person in turn. A hippotherapy session is that same loop, made physical instead of just electrical: a nervous system that struggles to regulate itself borrows, for thirty minutes at a time, the massive, unhurried, four-legged regulation of an animal that has never once needed therapy to know how to walk.

Chapter Fifteen: What We Call Comfort Now

In February 2018, a woman named Ventiko arrived at Newark airport with two paid tickets: one for herself, one for her peacock. His name was Dexter. She had raised him after losing his mate and her offspring, and by her own account his behaviour had changed after that loss badly enough that she felt she couldn't leave him behind. United Airlines turned them away, citing his size and weight, and a photograph of a full-grown peacock being wheeled through an airport on a luggage cart went, almost instantly, everywhere. It became one of the defining images of a genuine cultural moment: the years when “emotional support animal” had expanded, in practice, to cover almost anything a person could get onto a leash, a harness, or in Dexter's case, a baggage trolley.

I want to be careful here to hold two true things at once, because collapsing them into each other is exactly the mistake that made the peacock a punchline instead of a real story. The first true thing: animals genuinely help people regulate distress, and this book has spent its whole length building the case for that. The second true thing: for a real stretch of the last two decades, US federal rules drew almost no distinction between a dog trained for years to detect a seizure or interrupt a panic attack, and a pet that simply made its owner feel calmer, and airlines were required to accommodate both more or less identically, for free, with no training standard attached to the second category at all. That gap between the two categories is where the whole phenomenon actually lives, and where most of the genuine unfairness in this story sits.

The comedian Maeve Higgins told the story on Irish television

in 2018, cheerfully and without apparent hesitation at first: she'd bought a fake "service dog" vest online for her pet, Shadow, to avoid paying to fly him between the US and Ireland, obtained a letter citing anxiety, and sailed through one airport's cursory inspection before a second airport's staff pushed back harder. The backlash was immediate and, I think, entirely fair. Organisations that train genuine assistance dogs for people with disabilities pointed out exactly what this book has already shown you should matter: a real service dog represents years of specialised training, and every fraudulent vest in an airport makes gate staff, and fellow passengers, a little more suspicious of the next real one that comes through. Higgins apologised. The apology doesn't undo the pattern — by 2020, the US Department of Transportation reported enough fraudulent claims, and enough incidents of untrained animals behaving badly in cabins, that it rewrote the entire federal rule: as of January 2021, only dogs individually trained to perform a specific task for a disability count as service animals at all. Emotional support animals, regardless of species, are now legally just pets, and airlines are free to charge for them accordingly. Dexter the peacock would not even get as far as the check-in counter today.

I looked into a case you specifically asked me to check, because this book has made a promise not to present a secondhand story as verified fact without saying so. Steve-O, formerly of *Jackass*, met a street dog in Peru during a mountaineering shoot, a German shepherd mix he named Wendy, who followed him for days before he decided to bring her home. What I can confirm, from his own public account and press coverage at the time, is that Wendy went through actual professional training afterward, both as a service dog and as a therapy dog, and now travels with him and visits hospitalised children between trips. What I could not independently confirm is the more specific version of the story as you described it to me — a vest obtained purely as a paperwork shortcut, with no real training behind it. Separately, and genuinely, Steve-O has made public comedy content specifically about the loopholes in service-dog law and how easily an untrained pet can travel under a fake vest, which suggests he's well aware of the exact scam this chapter is describing, whether or not it describes his own dog. I'd rather tell you honestly that the story sits somewhere between "fully verified" and "can't confirm," than dress up a stronger claim than what I actually found.

What I keep coming back to, holding both the peacock and Wendy and Maeve Higgins's dog Shadow side by side, is that none of this actually disproves anything this book has argued so far. It just proves that anything true and valuable enough to matter to people will eventually attract people trying to get its benefits without doing the work that earns them. My father never once needed a vest, a letter, or a federal regulation to prove his cows made way for him. A real service dog doesn't need one either, not really, except that the world outside the barn runs on paperwork the way a barn never had to. The animals were never the problem in this story. What we built around them, and who started gaming what we built, is where the whole thing got complicated.

Coda: We Are Unmistakably Animal

Here is everything I've handed you, laid out in one place, the way I'd lay it out for my own father if he were still willing to sit still long enough to hear the whole case made in order.

A dairy farmer's cows moved for his open hand, ran to his red bakkie across a whole grazing camp, and once, exactly once, broke him, over a bag of kitchen sugar that arrived too late for the animal it was meant to save. A woman in the Bahamas spent twenty-five years pulling hooks from the mouths of wild sharks, and the sharks, who owed her nothing and had every evolutionary reason to keep their distance, kept choosing to come back. My dogs read a room before I've said a word in it, and one of them, once, read her own mistake clearly enough to disappear for forty-five minutes and come back low and ashamed. My cats arrive on a schedule that isn't mine, do something that looks like maintenance, and leave. One chicken, out of thirty otherwise anonymous birds, decided on her own that I was worth a bow.

Then the evidence, held up next to the lived thread rather than instead of it, exactly as uneven and contested as it honestly is. Dean Radin's forty years of laboratory work arguing that attention and intention travel further than mainstream science has a mechanism for yet, evidence he himself calls stronger than assumed and nowhere near proven. Rupert Sheldrake's dog who waited by the window fifty-five percent of the time his owner was on her way home, and the other researchers who ran the same experiment and disagreed with his conclusion, both sides still standing by their numbers decades later. Merlin Sheldrake's forests, wired underground into decentralised con-

versations that never needed a brain to happen. HeartMath's horses and dogs, hearts falling into rhythm with a calm human's, alongside Joe Dispenza's boldest claims, which I've tried to hand you honestly rather than dressed up as more settled than they are. Diana Reiss and Lori Marino's dolphins, self-aware by the same gold-standard test we accept for chimpanzees, who paid for that proof with shortened lives in tanks too small for what they'd just been shown to be. Mesmer, wrong about his invisible fluid and right, somehow, that something real was moving through that Paris salon, real enough to become modern hypnotherapy a century later. Jackal-headed gods born out of real jackals at the edge of real graveyards, a bull carrying Shiva because a bull's nature was Shiva's nature, ravens who were Thought and Memory, an eland painted on rock shelter walls for tens of thousands of years by people going somewhere in trance that we're still only beginning to understand. And a jaguar, walking uninvited into the visions of strangers on opposite sides of the world who never spoke to each other, showing up not as a threat but as a teacher, at the exact furthest edge of what a human mind can reach.

A sharpened blade hidden from the animal it's about to be used on, because a tradition half a world from my father's farm had independently arrived at his exact rule: a death owed to an animal is a death owed cleanly. A people in South Sudan who wash in what their cattle leave behind rather than feel a moment's disgust at it, because nothing that comes from the animal that sustains them was ever beneath them to begin with. A child who cannot make her own body cooperate, borrowing a horse's walk for thirty minutes at a time because the horse's rhythm can do, on loan, what her own legs can't do alone. And a peacock, wheeled through an airport on a luggage cart, at the exact unglamorous point where something real about animals and comfort curdled into something people learned to fake — proof, if anything, of how much everyone already understood the real thing was worth.

None of that, taken piece by piece, is proof of anything in the way a courtroom would want proof. Taken together, it stops looking like coincidence to me. It looks like the same signal, arriving independently in a Grootvlei dairy barn and a Bahamian reef and a parapsychology lab and an Amazonian ceremony and a temple on the Nile, each one picking it up with whatever instrument it had on hand, and each one, in its own language, reporting the same finding: the wall we built be-

tween “human” and “animal” was always thinner, and more recently built, than we’ve let ourselves believe.

I think we drew that wall for good reasons, some of them. It let us eat what we needed to eat, use what we needed to use, survive winters and predators and each other. But I don’t think the wall was ever a fact about the world. I think it was a convenience we agreed to stop questioning, and every piece of evidence in this book is a small crack in it, appearing in places its builders never expected to find one: a cow that wouldn’t fully yield to anyone but the man who’d earned it, a chicken who picked exactly one human out of a flock to bow to, a dog who understood, with no shared language at all, that something had gone wrong and it was hers to answer for.

My father never read a page of Dean Radin, and would not have known what to do with a mirror test if you’d handed him one. He didn’t need either. He knelt to those animals for a whole working life because some part of him had already done the arithmetic this entire book has spent its length trying to show its work for. We are not a separate species that stepped outside the animal kingdom to observe it from a safe, superior distance. We are one of its members, still, mostly, underneath every tool and word and wall we’ve built to convince ourselves otherwise — reading each other, recognising each other, occasionally grieving each other, across every species line we drew and never quite managed to make real.

We are unmistakably animal. My father knew it with his hands. I’ve spent this whole book trying to know it with my head, and arrived, in the end, at the exact same place he never had to leave.

— Andries J. Greyling

Homo Animalus is complete in first draft as of 2026-07-29: dedication, author’s note, fifteen chapters, and a coda. It has not been through a craft pass, a sensitivity read (Chapter Eleven specifically), or fact-verification beyond the sources logged in `canon/SOURCES.md`. Not committed, not wired into the public site — that decision belongs to the author.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor